

Democrats need a bluer national environment to flip South Carolina

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【メール原文】

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US diesel export restrictions now unlikely
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Summit lowers odds of year-end US-China truce breakdown

Democrats need a bluer national environment to flip South Carolina. Democrats’ once-fanciful hopes of flipping the South Carolina Senate seat are looking a little less unrealistic these days, with Senator Darline Graham (R-SC), who took office just earlier this summer following the death of her brother Lindsey Graham, leading Democrat Annie Andrews by only a few points in every poll of the race so far.

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South Carolina is part of a recurring pattern for Republicans this year, appearing also in Kansas and Nebraska: A strong Democratic gain across the board, coupled with relatively weak candidates, has made these races much closer than, in theory, they should be.
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In South Carolina, the ten-point shift toward Democrats in the national environment means that the state, which Trump won by 18 points in 2024, now leans only eight points toward Republicans. Graham’s obvious weaknesses as a candidate, which were on stark display during the Republican primary in August, contribute to another few points for Democrats, putting Andrews in a position where she can hope to win the seat.
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Still, we think South Carolina’s partisan baseline is probably too Republican for Democrats to flip the state this year; Democrats are leading or tied in states that voted for Trump by between 10 and 13 points in 2024, but not by more. If the generic congressional ballot moved another two points toward Democrats, though, South Carolina would a plausible pickup.

US diesel export restrictions now unlikely. We have revised our odds of US diesel export restrictions down to 40% (from 65%), mainly due to the sharp market reaction to potential restrictions late last

week. However, the administration continues to debate these measures and all options are on the table.

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Secretary of Energy Chris Wright continues to pressure refiners to agree to voluntary export reductions, and the White House will likely include the proposal early this week. These reductions are not enforceable and would create legal risk for refiners if implemented—both points suggest they will not have a significant effect.

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Implementation is a key tipping point. While our view that Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) export licenses were the easiest method to impose an export curb still holds, hesitation from within the Department of Commerce meant the administration had to consider other options. The most obvious, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA), comes with substantial downside risks.

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Domestic policy changes and diplomatic pressure on the EU to utilize its own refined product reserves are most likely to come to fruition, but unlikely to bring diesel prices down sufficiently to mollify groups demanding immediate relief. That means the market-rattling idea of export curbs will likely resurface if prices continue to move higher.

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For more, please see [Export restrictions now unlikely in US response to diesel prices](#) , 27 September 2026.

Summit lowers odds of year-end US-China truce breakdown. Our odds of a US-China truce breakdown before 2027 have fallen to 15% (from 30%) following the leaders' renewed commitment to preserving stable bilateral relations and plans for two more meetings in this calendar year.

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Washington and Beijing remain constrained by reciprocal economic leverage, particularly China's rare-earth coercive capacity which—alongside Beijing's interest in stability ahead of its 2027 Party Congress—underpins the managed-stability basecase.

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The prospective AI safety dialogue signals that the Trump administration will likely defer major technology controls, and while upcoming meetings and delayed Taiwan arms sales should further contain escalation, US decoupling actions may still prompt Chinese retaliation.

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This morning the US Trade Representative released lists of \$30 billion of trade that will be considered for reduced tariffs by each side. The US list mostly concentrates relief on consumer goods, while the Chinese list focuses on agriculture. This is a constructive development toward maintaining the ongoing trade truce, and represents a small substantive outcome from the summit, but it doesn't suggest that larger reductions are in the offing.

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For more, please see [Summit lowers odds of year-end bilateral breakdown](#) , 25 September 2025.

Quote of the Day

"Donald Trump commits impeachable offenses every week. But the truth is, we've done it twice...The top priority has to be stopping and slowing the Trump agenda." - Rep. Robert Garcia (D-CA), quoted by Punchbowl News, detailing Democrats' early discussions about their investigatory and legislative agenda

post-midterms. Rep. Garcia, the likely next chair of the House Oversight Committee, has reportedly met with Rep. Jamie Raskin (D-MD), the likely next chair of the House Judiciary Committee, to coordinate their execution of investigations – Oversight is likely to take up the Jeffrey Epstein probe and Judiciary to target President Trump's DOJ. This falls in line with House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries' direction for Democrats to "hold the crooks accountable" but with a new, added wrinkle that their approach may steer clear of impeachment proceedings to maximize political optionality and impact.

On the Radar

2 October: Last day Senate is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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